how exactly he was expanding India's presence in Central Asia.[60] Apart from economic interests, India also wanted to ensure Central Asian support at the UN on Kashmir.[61]

Swamy, the big conciliator, visited Afghanistan on 31 December 1990 and 1 January 1991, in his capacity as minister of commerce with additional charge of the ministry of law and justice, and met the top brass of the Afghan government, ranging from Najibullah to Wakil. Their discussions ranged from regional politics, to trade and commerce. Unlike before, Swamy found a surprisingly high amount of interest among his parliamentary colleagues on the exact nature and extent of India-Afghanistan trade and its future prospects.[62] With the economy at its lowest ebb, India's foreign policy was being strongly dictated by economics, and Afghanistan was not to be left behind. Trade between the two countries stood at Rs. 56 crores (approx. 0.86 USD) in 1988–89 and rose to Rs. 105.18 crores (approx. 1.6 USD) in 1989–90. The figure, it was expected, was to rise to Rs. 120 crore by the end of 1991, signifying a sharp rise (even if it was little relative to other countries).[63] However, at the heart of the debate, was the issue of land routes. India wanted to export more to Afghanistan (even though this made the Afghan leadership uncomfortable for fear of developing high levels of trade deficit), and connect to the resource-rich Central Asian Republics. But how? The problem in 1992 was not related to Pakistan which was ready to allow India to use its territory for exporting goods to Afghanistan. It had to do directly with India's relations with the Mujahideen. As Swamy explained, 'it is possible to go through Pakistan, but then we have to pass through Mujahideen territory and we have not really done anything concrete'.[64] Other options included opening an air link to Kabul or to use Iran's Bandar Abbas port to connect at the Islam Qala border in West Afghanistan's Herat province. Both options were prohibitively expensive in 1991. The need to constructively engage with the Mujahideen, thus, had never been more pressing.

In this context, though the communists challenged the government's acceptance of fundamentalists in Kabul, the conciliators received multi-party support when the Rao doctrine was implemented in 1992.[65] E. Ahamed, leader of the Indian Union Muslim League (IUML) from Kerala who later became minister-of-state for external affairs (2011–14), eagerly supported Rao's initiative.